

WOOING THE SISTERHOOD
The Mahayuti leaders with some of the beneficiaries of its flagship scheme

a senior party leader. The consolidation of the Hindu sentiment, says the NCP(SCP) functionary, saw them gravitate toward Shinde and the BJP rather than Uddhav, who was seen to have diluted his party's Hindutva agenda by allying with the Congress. "Thackeray has been unable to balance his Hindutva with his new secular makeover. This has estranged his core voters," says Deshpande. Uddhav may now be forced to revisit the wisdom of being branded 'pro-Muslim'

His party wants Uddhav to step out of the MVA as its dilution of Hindutva is being seen as the major reason for the Sena's core base deserting Sena (UBT)

in the era of majoritarian politics. Meanwhile, the transfer of Muslim votes his party saw in some seats could vanish the moment the party is forced to take a stand on issues such as the Uniform Civil Code. There is already pressure within the Uddhav Sena to part ways with the MVA, a sentiment voices in the Congress are also echoing.

Old warhorse that he is, Pawar Sr has vowed to rebuild the party's base. Unfortunately for the octogenarian, age is not on his side. Also, as a senior Maratha leader points out, the problem with the patriarch's politics is that it relies on sub-regional satraps who cannot survive without access to power, not on a cadre built organically. Knives are also out in the Grand Old Party. Factionalism, state chief Nana Patole's style of leadership, lack of second rung leaders... a senior Congress leader blames them all for the party's failure to live up to the promise it showed in the Lok Sabha polls.

If there is one thing this election has done, it is that it has ended the uncertainty of the past few years and steered the state toward a definitive trajectory. Whatever the electorate's quarrel with the manner in which the state's two regional parties were split, all now seems forgiven and forgotten. Good governance is all what they expect now and that is what the new dispensation must deliver. ■

THE COST OF WELFARE

Together, the various welfare schemes in Maharashtra could exceed ₹90,000 crore. This, when the state budget has projected a debt burden of ₹7.8 lakh crore

↘ Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana
Rs 1,500 per month to women from economically weaker sections
Beneficiaries: 23 million
Cost: ₹46,000 crore*

↘ 100% fee waiver for girls
From EWS, OBC and SEBC categories pursuing higher education
Beneficiaries: 205,000
Cost: ₹2,000 crore

↘ Annapurna Yojana
Three free LPG cylinders for Ladki Bahin and PM Ujjwala Yojana beneficiaries
Beneficiaries: 5.2 million
Cost: ₹829 crore

↘ Mukhyamantri Baliraja Mofat Vij Yojana
Free electricity to agricultural pumps with capacity up to 7.5 HP
Beneficiaries: 4.4 million
Cost: ₹14,761 crore

↘ Magel Tyala Saur Krushi Pump Yojana
Solar powered pumps for farmers
Beneficiaries: 850,000
Cost: ₹27,000 crore

↘ Mukhyamantri Yuva Karya Prashikshan Yojana
₹10,000 monthly stipend for youth as part of internship scheme
Beneficiaries: 1 million
Cost: ₹10,000 crore

↘ Mukhyamantri Vayoshri Yojana
₹3,000 each to senior citizens (above 65 years) to buy assisted living devices
Beneficiaries: 1.25-1.5 million
Cost: ₹450 crore

**Promised hike of ₹600 per month for projected 25 million beneficiaries will take total cost to ₹63,000 crore annually*